

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

TO ELECT OR TO SELECT

Intense lobbying has begun within the Congress for the coveted membership of the party's highest decision-making body—the Congress Working Committee (CWC). With the next plenary scheduled in February in Raipur, the party will have to form the next CWC, a process that had been suspended after Mallikarjun Kharge was elected party president. The party constitution enjoins that 12 of the CWC's 23 members be elected, but during Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi's presidencies, selection was via nomination. Election of CWC members was a key demand of the G23 Congress rebels. One does not know if Kharge will revert to election of CWC members. Not many may be willing to trust his discretion on the subject the way they did with the Gandhis.

SELECTIVE PROTEST



SONU KISHAN

Back in November 2020, in the run-up to the assembly election in Bihar, it was not just **Tejashwi Yadav**'s promise of 1 million jobs that caught the electorate's attention but also his famous announcement that he would withhold MLA salaries if required to pay those he would be recruiting. Two years hence, the *mahagathbandhan* government in which he is the deputy chief minister, has raised the salaries of MLAs and MLCs, the Opposition BJP is supporting the protesting aspirants of teaching jobs, but is shying from attacking the government's decision to hike the salaries of lawmakers.

Armed with Friends

Bhim Army chief **Chandrashekhar Azad**, seen campaigning for the Samajwadi Party-Rashtriya Lok Dal candidates in the recent Uttar Pradesh bypolls, is likely to go with the same alliance in the 2024 Lok Sabha election too. RLD chief Jayant Chaudhary had a big role in bringing Chandrashekhar into the opposition fold. Though he lost his security deposit in the last election when he contested against Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath in Gorakhpur, Chandrashekhar's latest collaboration is being seen as a win-win for both the alliance and Dalit groups. Quite popular among Dalit youth in western UP, Chandrashekhar now seems all set to take on the BJP with his new friends.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Kaushik Deka with Amitabh Srivastava, Prashant Srivastava, Rohit Parihar and Romita Datta



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Surprise Ahead

What are Prime Minister **Narendra Modi** and home minister **Amit Shah** planning for Rajasthan? The BJP unit here has some half a dozen chief ministerial aspirants, but none with the confidence to lead the party to victory in 2023. Immediate signals on changes in the state unit are expected in December. While the Modi-Shah duo may spring a surprise underdog to lead the party in the election battle, former chief minister Vasundhara Raje, Union ministers Gajendra Singh Shekhawat and Arjun Meghwal, and Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla will likely get specific responsibilities. Watch this space.



AN EQUAL HOLIDAY

West Bengal chief minister **Mamata Banerjee**, it seems, believes in being fair to all religions, castes, and creeds. This year, she has decided to declare December 26 a holiday too, since Christmas falls on Sunday. Earlier, she had done the same with Saraswati Puja, which fell on a Sunday. Last year, this privilege was extended for Eid and Chhath Puja. No one does political secularism better than Didi for sure.